

board priced at Rs. 12,000 will interest many. With the Intel Core 2 Duo processors almost extinct, these boards will follow the same fate very soon. Go for these systems when you have few plans of upgrading this rig a year or so from now.



Gigabyte P55-UD3R

For the Core i7 and Core i7 processors, there aren't any boards today that have onboard graphics solutions. For the LGA775, there are Intel's G45, G43 and G41 chipsets from different vendors. NVIDIA also makes the popular GeForce 9300 chipset that performs as well as the 780G from AMD for their platform. The GeForce 9300 boards are more expensive though. The MSI P7NGM is Rs. 6,000 and the ASUS P5N7A for Rs. 8,200. I find I'm better off spending on a basic graphics card instead for paying the premium for performance. Intel chipsets are capable of handling HD with the help of faster Core 2 Duo processors, but they don't come close to the GeForce 9300 in games I've noticed. For really basic office systems that will be used to browse the net and work on office applications, any of the boards based on Intel's G45, G43 or G41 chipsets will suffice. Those boards are just a few hundred rupees cheaper.

On the AMD side of things, all the processors today are based on the AM3 socket. Since the AM2+ and AM3 sockets are quite similar, it's best to look for an AM3 ready sticker before purchasing the board anyway. If you are buying a really high-end Phenom processor, then also look for the power ratings of the board that are compatible with the processor. Some boards specifically mention a 140-W CPU support. Look for those just in case you go in for a really powerful CPU.

Another friend of mine wanted to build an HTPC and he was looking for a good on-board graphics solution. Going the AMD way made a lot of sense and the AMD780G has proved to be perfect for many people. The newer 785G brings a slight improvement in performance, but many boards use DDR3 RAM. Still, I suggested the ASUS M4A78-HTPC/RC to him. We found this board for Rs. 7,000 in one of the shops and it made very good sense especially because it came with a remote control. This means you can sit away from the computer and handle the media operations using the remote instead of a